

2 Complete the sentences with either the present simple or the present continuous form of the verbs in brackets.

- 1 I for a long walk three times a week after work. (go)
- 2 I my friend Max at the cinema tonight. (meet)
- 3 It really annoys me when people to my texts. (not reply)
- 4 Cycling a more popular way to travel around cities. (become)
- 5 Can you call back later? Fred his dad in the garden at the moment. (help)
- 6 I'll order a takeaway for dinner. you Indian food or Chinese food? (prefer)

UNIT 2

Past tenses

Past simple

The past simple is used for past events or actions:

He **closed** the front door, **locked** it, and **set** off to work.
In the end, we **decided** not to move house.

The past simple is often used with a specific time:

The previous director **retired** in November.
She **wrote** her first novel in 2001.

Past continuous

The past continuous is used for a continued action which was happening when another action took place:

We arrived at the theatre just as the show **was starting**.

In many cases, the continued action is interrupted:

When he **called**, I **was watching** my favourite soap opera.
(His call interrupted me.)

The past continuous is also often used to set the scene at the beginning of a story:

It **was raining** hard and an icy wind **was blowing**. Alex knew the journey would be impossible.

The past continuous cannot normally be used with stative verbs:

My grandparents rarely **disagreed** with each other. ✓
My grandparents ~~were rarely disagreeing~~ with each other.

For a list of common stative verbs, see Grammar reference Unit 1: present tenses.

1 Choose the correct options to complete the sentences.

- 1 While I *listened* / *was listening* to music, my brother *was playing* / *played* in the garden.
- 2 My friends *often phoned* / *were often phoning* me every evening.
- 3 While I *was baking* a cake, I *realised* / *was realising* that the recipe was wrong.
- 4 It was a beautiful day. The sun *shone* / *was shining* and the birds *sang* / *were singing*.
- 5 Simone Biles *won* / *was winning* four gold medals at the USA at the Rio Olympics.

2 Complete the sentences with the past simple or the past continuous form of the verbs in brackets.

- 1 While I (pack) for my holiday, I (find) some old sunglasses.
- 2 As I (leave) the restaurant, I (realise) that I'd left my scarf behind.
- 3 While Mark (practise) the piano, he (watch) TV.
- 4 When we (hear) the protests, we (stop) what we (look) out of the window.
- 5 My computer (crash) while I (write) my essay.

Past perfect

The past perfect is used to show that an action happened earlier than another past action:

The police **were unaware** that the attacker **had already escaped**. (The attacker escaped before the police realised.)

Sometimes it is not necessary to use the past perfect if it is very clear which action happened first:

After we **finished** eating, we played cards.

Past perfect continuous

The past perfect continuous is used for a continued action which happened before another past action:

We **'d been working** so hard that we decided to take a break. (We took a break after a continued period of work.)

The past perfect continuous can be used to show how long an action continued up to a certain point in the past:

When the search began, the girl **had already been missing** for two days. (She was missing for two days before the search began.)

3 Complete the sentences with the past perfect or the past perfect continuous form of the verbs in brackets.

- 1 We were furious, because we over two hours before the train arrived at the station.
- 2 She (write) poetry for over three years before she finally decided to try to get some poems published.

- 3 Martha's children devoured the cake that she (bake) only an hour ago.
- 4 I must have dropped the letter that she (hand) to me.
- 5 When they got home, they discovered that their babysitter (already read) their toddler a bedtime story.
- 6 When I finally reached the front of the queue, I found out that my sister (pick up) the tickets an hour earlier.

4 Complete the sentences with the past perfect simple or continuous form of the verbs in brackets.

- 1 The waiter, who was under a lot of pressure, brought a starter that I (not order).
- 2 I had great difficulty recalling the poem I (try) to memorise the previous night.
- 3 The children excitedly collected the fruit that (fall) from the trees.
- 4 She (play) tennis all afternoon when we glimpsed her briefly as we walked past the park.
- 5 I (read) a chapter of my book every evening for over two weeks, so I was upset when I forgot to take my book with me on holiday.
- 6 He (live) in Paris all his life and was reluctant to move, even when he got married.



used to / didn't use to

The structure *used to* + infinitive is used for repeated actions, habits or states in the past:

Before the internet, people **used to write** letters a lot more.

The negative form of this structure is *didn't use to*:

We **didn't use to have** a dishwasher in our old house.

Used to is not normally used with time expressions which specify the duration of the action:

I **smoked** for ten years, but then I gave up. ✓

~~I used to smoke for ten years, but then I gave up.~~

Would + infinitive can also be used for actions and habits in the past:

When I was a child, my dad **would** always tell me a story at bedtime.

However, *would* cannot be used to talk about past states:

This collection of paintings **used to belong** to a rich family. ✓

~~This collection of paintings would belong to a rich family.~~
(*Belong* is a stative verb.)

5 Complete the sentences with the correct form of *used to* and the verbs in brackets.

- 1 I eating spinach when I was a child, but now I love it! (– / enjoy)
- 2 Her friend judo, but now she trains twice a week. (– / do)
- 3 They hours playing football in the park. (+ / spend)
- 4 My mother a beautiful grand piano. (+ / own)
- 5 she in touch with her relatives before they emigrated to New Zealand? (? / keep)
- 6 I the sound of fireworks when I was young. (– / like)

6 Tick the correct sentences. Correct the sentences with mistakes.

- 1 My dad would play in a band before he got married.
- 2 I would work in a hotel for many years in my youth.
- 3 When she was younger, she would enjoy playing the flute and would practise every day.
- 4 I would live in London near Hyde Park until I left to go to university in Nottingham.
- 5 When I was a kid I would play in the park with my friends until it was quite dark and my mother called me to go in.
- 6 I didn't use to enjoy the taste of seafood, until I had the chance to eat some fresh mussels in Scotland last year.

UNIT 3

Modal verbs

ability

To express ability in the present, we use *can* or *be able to*:

On a clear day, you **can see** the mountains from my balcony.
I'm **not able to read** without my glasses.

For general ability in the past, we use *could* or *be able to*:

The sea was warm, so we **were able to swim** all year round.
In the old days you **could buy** everything at the local market.

However, when we are talking about ability on one specific occasion in the past, we only use *be able to*, not *could*:

Luckily we didn't get lost because Alice **was able to get** directions from someone. ✓ (specific occasion)

~~Luckily we didn't get lost because Alice could get directions from someone.~~